UNBANKED WOMEN: ECONOMIC EMPOWERMENT USING HALAQOH MODEL IN SHARIA MICRO FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS

Abstract

Background: Women are crucial to many facets of the economy, so their empowerment is the primary tenet of global economic growth. However, women often experience discrimination and limited access to formal bank financial services for entrepreneurial activities.

Aims: This study aims to explore and analyze the Halaqoh model as an economic empowerment strategy for women who do not have access to financial services through Islamic microfinance institutions.

Research Methode: This study uses qualitative analysis involving 95 respondents spread across 4 different provinces. The data collection method of this research includes observation and interviews. The collected data underwent a thematic analysis to establish trends and important discoveries pertinent to the study's goals.

Results and Conclusion: The halaqoh model implemented by Micro Waqf Bank has proven effective in improving women's economic welfare through sharia micro-financing.

Contribution: The government and stakeholders can use the practical implications of this study to establish Sharia Microfinance Institutions (SMIs) based on Micro Waqf Bank as the foundation for empowering women without bank accounts to engage in economic activity.

Keywords: Economic Empowerment, Halaqoh Model, Sharia Micro Financial, Unbanked Women

Introduction

Women are crucial in many facets of life, such as economic engagement, empowerment, and financial decision-making. These three factors significantly affect households and the surrounding environment, according to an earlier study (Chen & Sun, 2023; Mabrouk et al., 2023; Wang et al., 2022). Women with higher financial literacy positively affect the quality of children's nutrition and education (Grohmann & Schoofs, 2021). In addition, women's involvement in financial decisions also improves the quality of family health and well-being (Banerjee & Gogoi, 2023).

Therefore, women's empowerment is the main pillar of global economic development. According to the UN Women (2025), women's active participation in the economic sector can increase the global economy by up to USD 7 trillion. Women's involvement in economic empowerment improves individual welfare and creates a more inclusive and sustainable community welfare. This aligns with Yeboah et al.'s (2022) and Omran & Bilan (2022) research, which shows that women's participation in economic empowerment correlates positively with increased gross domestic taxes in Sub-Saharan Africa and Egypt. In addition, this empowerment effort can potentially reduce tingkat poverty, expand access to education, and improve health services (Boadi et al., 2024; Das et al., 2024; Fagbemi et al., 2023).

Women's empowerment in the economic sector can be achieved through microfinance programs based on Islamic principles. The program provides access to capital for women and skills and insights into entrepreneurship (Hoque et al., 2022). According to Zitouni & Ben Jedidia (2022), These microfinance programs provide socio-economic benefits, including increased incomes and strengthening the role of women. In addition, the program can increase women's confidence and independence (Islam, 2021). Thus, the Islamic principle-based microfinance program is a strategic step in supporting women's empowerment and optimizing sustainable economic development.

One effective approach to women's empowerment in microfinance programs is the Halaqoh model. The approach focuses on collective learning and social support (Bastian et al., 2023; Lee & Huruta, 2022). With the implementation of this model, women can share experiences, knowledge, and skills in entrepreneurship, thereby creating an environment that supports growth and financial independence (Krieger et al., 2022). Research by Vershinina et al. (2022) shows that women's participation in halaqoh groups can increase motivation self-confidence, and strengthen social networks essential for business success. Thus, women gain economic benefits and build stronger and more resilient communities.

However, women often experience discrimination in various aspects of life, especially in the economic field. This discrimination is reflected in the wage gap between men and women, where women often receive lower pay for the same work (Guadalupe & Arturo, 2022; Howard et al., 2020). In addition, women have limited access to capital and financial resources (Dela Cruz et al., 2023). This has resulted in low participation of women in entrepreneurial activities. Women's limited access to financial services is exacerbated by social and cultural norms that often denigrate women's roles and lack of support for policies that favor women (Gillespie et al., 2022; Mansour et al., 2022). As a result, women are often marginalized in economic decision-making, contributing to a sustainable cycle of poverty.

Many productive poor women still have difficulty accessing loans from conventional banks. This hinders women from developing businesses and improving family welfare (Duvendack et al., 2023). Research Wang et al. (Wang et al., 2022) shows that women receive smaller business loans than men and face higher collateral requirements at conventional banks. In addition, women's accessibility to loan opportunities is often hampered due to social, cultural, and religious factors (Ranabahu & Tanima, 2022; Senou & Manda, 2022; Shohel et al., 2023). This gap not only limits the economic potential of women but also contributes to economic growth globally.

In addition, small businesses run by women face high credit risk due to a combination of structural, social, and economic factors (Chavoushi et al., 2021; Singh & Dash, 2021). This problem is complex and multi-dimensional. According to research by Chaudhuri et al. (2020), Financial institutions often view small and medium-sized enterprises managed by women as having a high risk of business vulnerability. In developing regions, structural barriers, such as poor listing, unstructured business plans, and market imperfections, have made financial institutions more cautious in providing loans primarily to women (Demir et al., 2022; Sakyi-Nyarko et al., 2022). Therefore, innovative approaches and more inclusive policies are needed to address these challenges and encourage women's economic participation.

On the other hand, many women still face limited access to entrepreneurship and financial management education (Noor et al., 2024). This is influenced by gender discrimination and cultural norms that limit women's participation in improving financial literacy (Fadzlyn & Muhammad, 2024). In addition, restrictions on access to entrepreneurship and financial literacy lead to low confidence, decision-making, and entrepreneurial networking (Santos et al., 2023; Srivastava, 2024). Therefore, there is a need for a financial literacy program that can bridge this knowledge gap.

Lack of access to business financing for women is a problem influenced by negative perceptions that women tend to use loans for consumptive purposes or to pay off debts. This perception is linked to gender roles, limited social capital, and structural vulnerabilities that women face in accessing formal financial services (Khan et al., 2020; Wang et al., 2022). Research Brickell et al. (2023) mentioned that many women take financial services to overcome debt and meet basic needs. This shows that women's financial needs are often urgent and complex, so a more inclusive and gender-sensitive approach is needed.

Therefore, this research is important, considering that many women still do not have access to formal banking services. This study introduces the halaqah model through Micro Waqf Bank as a new approach to empowering unbanked women. The model combines collective learning with Sharia principles (Afrida et al., 2024). This research aims to improve women's economic welfare through financial independence, which is realized through Micro Waqf Bank based on the halaqah model. In addition, this research is expected to be an innovative solution to reducing the gender gap in the financial sector while supporting inclusive and sustainable economic development.

Research Method

This research uses qualitative analysis with a thematic approach, including data collection, reduction, interpretation, and display. A qualitative descriptive study was carried out holistically to provide an in-depth understanding of the women's economic empowerment model based on Micro Waqf Bank. This study involved 95 women aged 30-49 in the Micro Waqf Bank program (Table 1). Respondents were spread across 4 provinces: Yogyakarta, West Sumatra, Central Java, and East Java.

The data collection method of this study includes observation of mandatory group training and customer mentoring process during the *Weekly Halaqah meeting.* Furthermore, interviews were conducted with Micro Waqf Bank's leaders, assistants, and customers to explore the respondents' perceptions and experiences regarding the women's economic empowerment model. The interviews are conducted in a structured and natural manner to build a comfortable atmosphere for the informants. The data obtained were analyzed thematically to identify patterns and key findings relevant to the research objectives (Saunders et al., 2023). Thus, this study provides a comprehensive overview of the implementation of the halaqah model and offers practical recommendations to improve the effectiveness of women's empowerment programs in the Islamic finance sector.

Table 1. Respondents' Sociodemography

Education			Age			Business length			Income After Obtaining Financing		
Education	Total	%	Age	Total	%	Business length	Total	%	Income (Rupiahs)	Total	%
Higher Education	9	9	>50 years	13	14	1-5 years	50	53	<1.9 million	27	29
Senior High School	54	57	40-49 years	37	39	6-10 years	28	29	2 -2.9 million	21	23
Junior High School	19	20	30-39 years	38	40	11-15 years	11	12	3 -3.9 million	30	32
Elementary School	13	14	29 years	7	7	>15 years	6	6	>4 million	17	17
Total Responden	95			95			95			95	

Results and Discussion

Sharia Microfinance Institutions (SMIs) can be an alternative to providing access to women, especially with economic limitations (Hassan et al., 2020). SMIs, with Sharia principles, tend to emphasize justice, transparency, and social welfare so that they can provide more adaptive and inclusive solutions to the financial services gap that women often face (Al-Qahtani et al., 2022; Dela Cruz et al., 2023; Mabrouk et al., 2023). SMIs institutions provide loans and empower women through financial training and education so that they can understand good financial management, improve business skills, and build social networks that support their businesses (Jay et al., 2022).

In addition, the existence of SMIs institutions also helps increase women's participation in the local economy. This is shown by women's easy access to capital to start or develop small businesses to create jobs and increase their family income (Graafland, 2020; Trujano & Lévesque, 2022). In addition, the increasing contribution of women to the economy is expected to improve the status and rights of women in society.

On the other hand, Micro Waqf Bank emerged as an innovation in social financing that focuses on empowering the community's economy through waqf funds. This concept aligns with the goals of Sharia Microfinance Institutions (SMIs), which seek to increase access to finance for women (Tok et al., 2022). Micro Waqf Bank utilizes waqf funds that are managed for the benefit of the community to provide more sustainable financing to women (Raman et al., 2022). In addition, Micro Waqf Bank supports business development, especially for women often marginalized in the formal banking system (Al-shami et al., 2021).

The results of interviews related to the stages of women's empowerment at Micro Waqf Bank can be seen in Figure 1. The stage begins with identifying prospective customers to determine the suitability of the program's target criteria. Furthermore, MWB socialization to the community is carried out through social gatherings and empowerment of family welfare to disseminate information about conception, stages of formation, participation requirements, and activities. Then, a survey and feasibility test of prospective customers were carried out to verify the correctness of low-income family data and assist in selecting prospective participants. Then, the Group Mandatory Pre-Training (GCP) is carried out before implementing General Community Training for prospective customers.

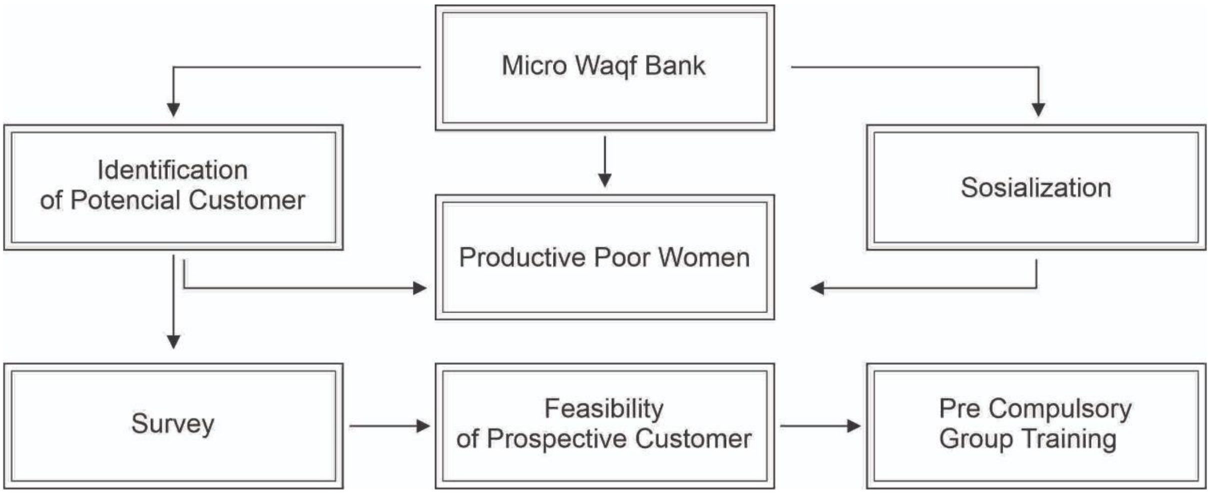

Figure 1. Stages of Women's Empowerment at Micro Waqf Bank

Women are empowered through CGT, provision of financing, and customer assistance. CGT is the initial stage of the empowerment program carried out by Micro Waqf Bank for women who do not have bank accounts. Management emphasizes the character of potential customers, including discipline, trust, responsibility, and concern for others. CGT is held after at least three groups of five members are formed and conducted for 1 hour on five consecutive days. In the implementation of CGT, the material presented includes several things that can be seen in Table 1.

Table 1. CGT Materials

Day	Material
First	1) Explanation of CGT, 2) Introduction to MWB. 3) Introduction and principles of CBGIBSI membership, Introduction of CGT participants, 4) Introduction of pledges, 5) Motivational materials.
Second	1) Reading of the pledge, 2) Capacity building material, 6) Rights and obligations of members, 7) Election of group leaders and deputy leaders, 8) Discussion of responsibilities of leaders, secretaries, and group members.
Third	1) Reading the pledge, 2) Introduction to contracts and financing procedures and installment payments, 3) Stories and creating a business profile.
Fourth	1) Reading of the pledge, 2) Giving the name and number of CBGIBSI, 3) Election of leaders and deputy leaders, 4) Discussion of the responsibilities of leaders, deputy leaders, and members, and 5) discussion of WH.
Fifth	1) Reading of the pledge, 2) Review of CGT materials, 3) CBGIBSI validation test.

Source: (BSM, 2017b)

Integrating SMIs and Micro Waqf Bank creates a strong synergy in empowering women and society (Lee & Huruta, 2022). Women are given wider access to financing to contribute to local economic growth. Thus, the status of women in society will increase, and women's rights will be fulfilled. In addition, this waqf-based financing model allows community participation in funding productive businesses to create a sense of ownership and responsibility collectively (Alhammadi, 2022). Thus, the collaboration between SMIs and Micro Waqf Bank can be a strong foundation for creating a sustainable economic ecosystem and emphasizing the important role of women in economic development.

The General Community Training process is a crucial starting point where group members can get to know each other and understand each other's capacities in running a business. With seating arrangements, each member can participate actively in discussions and share experiences to strengthen social networks supporting business success. The disbursement of financing made after the General Community Training ensures that all members have the same commitment and understand the shared responsibilities to minimize the risk of default. The financing process is disbursed in three stages with a 2-2-1 pattern. This pattern is a model that teaches caring attitudes among fellow members. Financing disbursements are sorted by level of urgency, where members who need it the most receive it first (Figure 2).

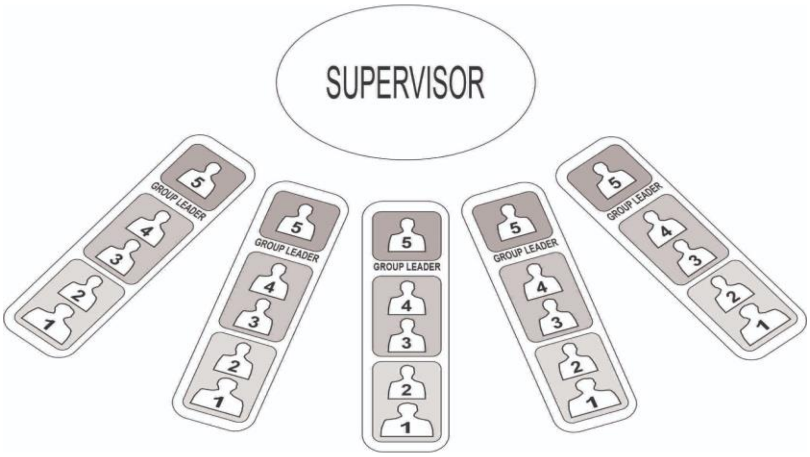

Figure 2. Group Member Seating Order Model
Source: The Micro Waqf Bank, 2019

Financing in Micro Waqf Bank is group-based with a pattern of shared responsibility known as kafalah in Islamic economics (Hidayat et al., 2022). This kafalah system strengthens group members' solidarity and creates a sense of mutual trust and responsibility in fund management (Boonstra et al., 2023). Micro Waqf Bank financing was disbursed after seating arrangements during the General Community Training (GCT) to build communication and cooperation between group members. In addition, this approach creates a collaborative learning environment where women gain access to capital and the skills and knowledge needed to manage their businesses. Thus, Micro Waqf Bank can positively contribute to sustainable economic growth as a financial institution.

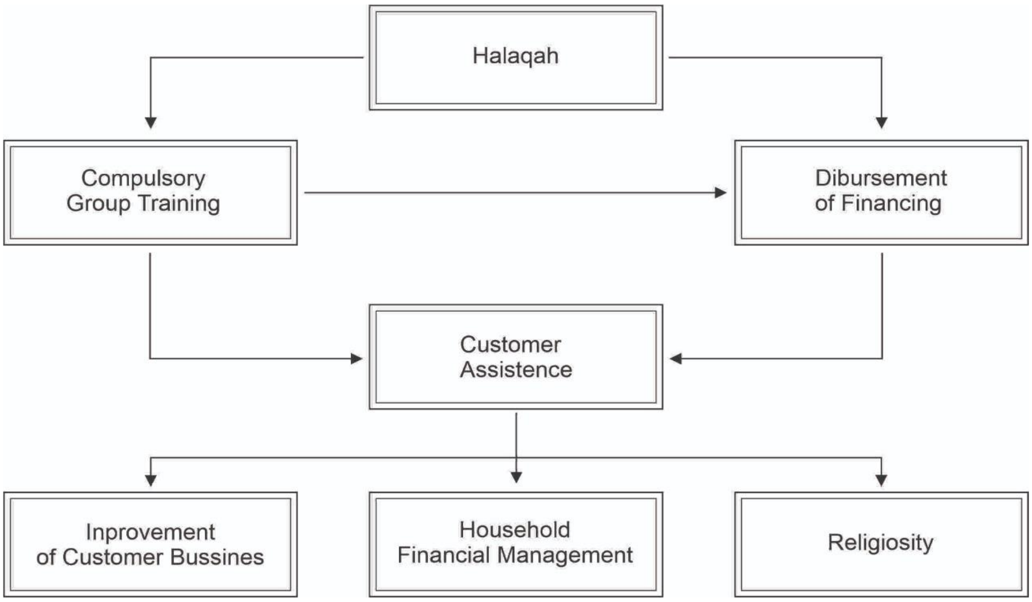

Figure 3. Implementation of *Halaqoh* in MWB

Micro Waqf Bank, with the halaqoh method, plays an important role in women's economic empowerment. The halaqoh method involves group discussions and collective learning, part of the MWB approach. This approach is considered to improve entrepreneurial skills and the ability to manage finances (Chavoushi et al., 2021). Through halaqoh activities, women can share knowledge and experience to strengthen social networks and increase economic independence (Dong et al., 2021). In addition, this collective approach also creates an environment that supports women in inspiring each other and building confidence (Soemitra et al., 2022; Vershinina et al., 2022). The implementation of the halaqoh model in MWB can be seen in Figure 3.

Table 2. *Halaqoh* Agenda at MWB

No	Material
1	Opening
2	Pledge reading
3	Member attendance report
4	Disbursement of financing
5	Customer Assistance
6	Installment payments
7	Prayer and closing

Source: (BSM, 2017a)

In implementing women's empowerment through the halaqoh method, supervision plays a crucial role in ensuring the program's effectiveness. The halaqoh method was carried out for 1 hour accompanied by a supervisor with several structured agendas (Table 2). Supervision is essential to improve the performance and motivation of participants involved in empowerment programs (Westgate et al., 2021). A monitoring framework that supports the implementation of women's empowerment can involve regular feedback and encouragement to increase the program's success index (Assegaai et al., 2021). In addition, structured supervision also allows for identifying challenges or obstacles participants face during the learning process so that solutions can be provided immediately (Assegaai et al., 2021; Charle-Cuéllar et al., 2021). Thus, the integration of good supervision in the halaqoh method not only supports the achievement of program objectives but can also contribute to the long-term sustainability of the empowerment program.

Conclusion

The halaqoh model implemented by Micro Waqf Bank has proven effective in improving women's economic welfare through sharia micro-financing. This model is considered very suitable for empowering women who do not have bank accounts. This study provides practical implications for the government and stakeholders to make Sharia Microfinance Institutions (SMIs) based on Micro Waqf Bank as the basis for economic empowerment of women who do not have bank accounts so that they can actively participate in economic activities and improve the welfare of their families. However, this study has some limitations. First, the study only focused on in-depth interviews with unbanked women at Micro Waqf Bank, so the findings may not fully represent the broader population. In addition, financing risk management in Sharia Microfinance Institutions (SMIs) is not discussed in this study, thus providing an opportunity for future studies to explore the topic further.

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